Nihara Macabando Panandigan

Nihara Macabando Panandigan is a Maranao political leader, community builder, and royal titleholder from Mulondo, Lanao del Sur, in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). She served two terms as Municipal Mayor of Mulondo and previously as its Vice Mayor, earning recognition for her inclusive governance style and her genuine care for the community's most vulnerable members. Beyond her political career, she carries the prestigious royal title of **Bae A Labi sa Ulo a Masiu**, a distinction that places her among the respected women leaders of the Maranao people.

Her legacy is defined by a hands-on approach to public service, from pioneering orphan care and social welfare programs to actively supporting the region's religious educators and institutions. She built her political foundation from the ground up, starting as a barangay chairwoman, and worked her way to becoming one of Mulondo's longest-serving chief executives. Today, she remains a central figure in the municipality's civic and family life.

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Nihara Macabando Panandigan	
	
Born	Mulondo, Lanao del Sur
Ethnicity	Maranao
Region	BARMM
Title	Bae A Labi sa Ulo a Masiu
Offices Held	Barangay Chairwoman, Marinaut, Marawi City; Vice Mayor, Mulondo (2013–2019); Municipal Mayor, Mulondo (2019–present, two terms)
Spouse	Mayor Abdulhakim O. Panandigan
Children	Khalid Macabando Panandigan (Vice Mayor, Mulondo)

Background

Nihara Macabando Panandigan comes from Mulondo, a municipality in Lanao del Sur within the BARMM. Her roots in the Maranao community run deep, evidenced both by her decades of public service and by her recognition as a royal titleholder under the traditional Maranao leadership structure.

Her public service story didn't start at the top. She first served as Barangay Chairwoman in Marinaut, Marawi City, where she developed a reputation for being responsive and community-centered. That grassroots foundation shaped the kind of leader she would become, someone who understood the day-to-day realities of her constituents before she ever took on a municipal office.

Career

Panandigan's career in elective politics spans multiple decades and positions. She served as Vice Mayor of Mulondo from 2013 to 2019, a six-year stint that prepared her well for the chief executive role. In 2019, she was elected Municipal Mayor of Mulondo, a position her constituents gave her with a clear mandate. She went on to serve two terms as mayor.

During her time as mayor, she led infrastructure improvements, telecommunications access initiatives, and public health and welfare programs across the municipality. Her administration consistently prioritized lifting living conditions for ordinary residents while strengthening the mechanisms of local governance.

Social Welfare Programs

One of the defining features of Panandigan's tenure was her focus on the most vulnerable members of her community. She is credited with pioneering two notable social welfare programs in the BARMM region.

The first is the **SIYAP KO MGA WATA ILO Program**, a care initiative for orphaned children. The second is the **SIYAP KO MGA TIBAYO Program**, which extends support to other disadvantaged groups. These programs reflect a clear philosophy in her governance: inclusive development means no one gets left behind, especially children and families with the least resources.

Support for Religious Institutions

Panandigan also made the support of the religious sector a priority during her administration. Under her watch, Imams and Bilal serving each Masjeed in the municipality received regular assistance from the Office of the Mayor. Madrasah institutions were similarly supported, and the Asatidz (faculty members) of these Madrasah received consistent aid as well.

This commitment to the religious and educational sector reflects her understanding of the central role that Islamic institutions and their leaders play in Maranao community life, not just in spiritual guidance but in moral formation and community cohesion.

Cultural Heritage and Royal Title

Beyond her political roles, Panandigan holds a significant position in the traditional leadership structure of the Maranao people. She carries the title of **Bae A Labi sa Ulo a Masiu**, a prestigious royal distinction bestowed upon women leaders who are recognized for their standing, character, and service within the community.

This title is not merely ceremonial. It connects her to a long tradition of Maranao women who have held respected positions within the datu system, and it adds a layer of cultural legitimacy to her public service that resonates deeply with her constituents.

Legacy and Family

Panandigan's public service legacy is now woven into her family's continued involvement in Mulondo's governance. Her husband, Abdulhakim O. Panandigan, currently serves as the municipality's mayor, while their son, Khalid Macabando Panandigan, serves as Vice Mayor. This continuity reflects the trust the community has extended to her family and the durable impact of her years in office.

As the First Lady of Mulondo, she remains an active and influential presence in the municipality's civic life, carrying forward the same advocacy for community welfare that defined her own years in leadership.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Mulondo, Lanao del Sur
- Maranao people
- Bae A Labi (traditional Maranao women's title)
- Profile provided by Aly PM (https://www.facebook.com/alys.mala)

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